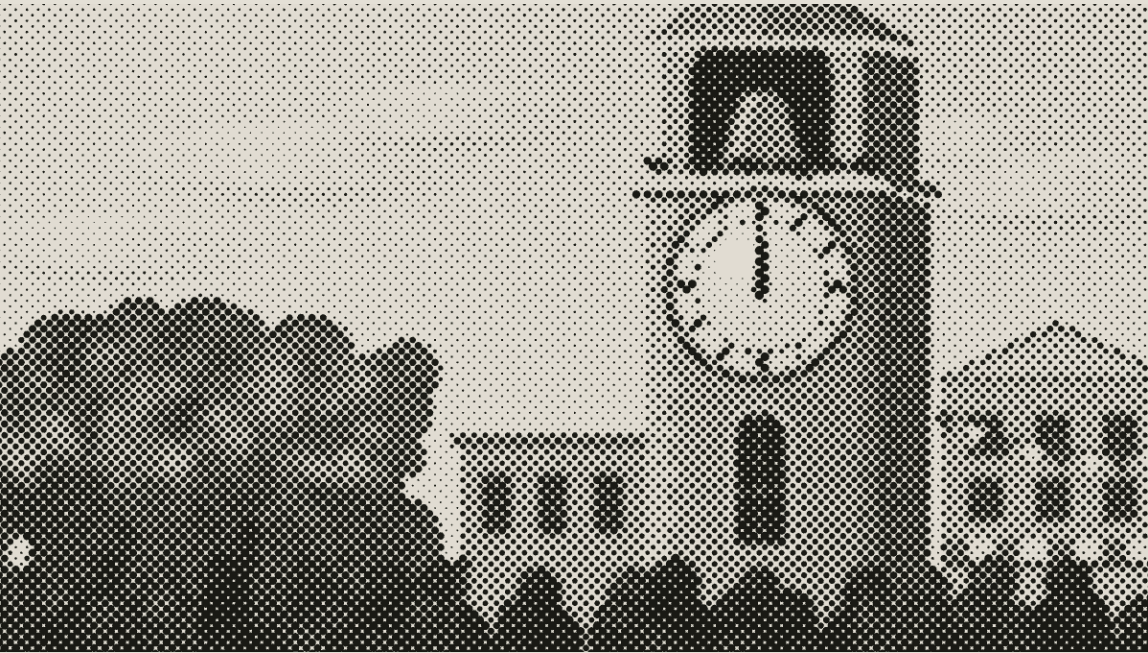


LOCAL

Clock tower ticks again after 31 silent years

Volunteers spent 14 months and 1,400 hours restoring Wickham Ferry’s 1904 Town Hall clock



NOON, SATURDAY — The Wickham Ferry Town Hall clock strikes 12 as about 300 people watch from Ferry Street. It had been silent since an ice storm in January 1995.
COURIER PHOTO / BEN ADEYEMI

“When it stopped, it felt like the town stopped listening to itself.

WALTER PRUITT, 81, WHO LED THE RESTORATION

BY INES CALLOWAY
COURIER STAFF WRITER

WICKHAM FERRY — At noon Saturday, the clock in the Wickham Ferry Town Hall tower struck 12 for the first time since an ice storm stopped it in January 1995.

About 300 people stood in Ferry Street to hear it. Some counted the strikes out loud. When the 12th one faded, the crowd applauded, and a few people cried.

“I wound that clock every Saturday when I was 14,” said Walter Pruitt, 81, a retired machinist who led the restoration. “When it stopped, it felt like the town stopped listening to itself.”

The clock went silent on Jan. 7, 1995, when ice snapped the cable that holds its drive weight. The falling weight cracked the escapement wheel, the part that lets the gears turn one tooth at a time. Repair estimates over the years ran as high as \$90,000, and the town never budgeted for one.

The restoration took 14 months and 46 volunteers, ages 16 to 86, who logged about 1,400 hours in the tower, according to the Wickham Ferry Clock Committee’s records. They cleaned and rebuilt the 1904 movement, rehung the 1,100-pound bell and reglazed all four 6-foot dials.

Students in the Tamsin Valley High School robotics club cut a replacement escapement wheel on the school’s milling machine, working from measurements of the cracked original.

“We had to make a part nobody has made in 120 years,” said Priya Raman, 17, who ran the mill. “The first four came out wrong. The fifth one ticks.”

The committee raised \$18,250. About \$11,200 of it came from 312 pies sold at the Saturday market by bakers from the Wickham Ferry Grange.

See CLOCK, Page A6

BY THE NUMBERS

31
years the clock stood silent

46
volunteers, ages 16 to 86

1,400
hours logged in the tower

312
pies sold at the Saturday market

\$18,250
raised in all

SOURCE: WICKHAM FERRY CLOCK COMMITTEE

School board adds second morning bus route

HARLOW — The Tamsin County School Board voted 5-2 Thursday to add a second morning bus route on the east side of the county. The route starts Nov. 2 and cuts the longest ride from 58 minutes to 35, Superintendent Glenn Marsh said.

Mill Road covered bridge reopens Monday

ASHGROVE — The Mill Road covered bridge reopens to bicycles and pedestrians Monday after a two-week repair of its deck. Cars remain barred until spring, the county roads department said.

CORRECTIONS

A story Saturday on Page A3 misspelled the name of the Ashgrove fire chief. He is Daniel Okonkwo.

Harvest Fair pie contest draws 140 entries, a record

HARLOW — Bakers entered 140 pies in the Tamsin County Harvest Fair contest Saturday, 31 more than last year and the most since the fair began

keeping count in 1962, organizers said. The judges tasted for six hours.

Rhubarb took the top ribbon for the third year in a row. The winner, Marguerite Osei of Ashgrove,

said she would not share the recipe. “It’s my grandmother’s, and she’d come back for it,” Osei said.

Results for all 14 categories are on Page B1.